Capture Management

& Relationship Building

in Government Contracting

A Field Guide from the Perspective of a Senior Capture Executive

Table of Contents

Capture Management & Relationship Building

BLUF

Capture management is the single highest-leverage activity in government contracting. The firms that win consistently — year over year, at scale — are not the most technically brilliant. They are the most strategically disciplined. This guide tells you exactly how they do it.

1. What Is Capture Management — Really?

I have run capture on contracts ranging from $50M task orders to multi-billion-dollar programs. Here is what nobody tells you in a textbook: capture management is not a process. It is a discipline. A mindset. A competitive commitment to own an opportunity so thoroughly that by the time the government publishes the solicitation, your firm is the only logical choice.

At its core, capture is the structured, pre-solicitation pursuit of a specific government contract. You are not waiting for the Request for Proposals (RFP) to drop. You are shaping requirements, building relationships with decision-makers, and pricing out your competition — all 12 to 24 months before a single word of that RFP is written.

I have watched companies with inferior solutions win $500M contracts because their capture discipline was flawless. I have also watched technically superior firms lose because they started capture when the RFP hit SAM.gov. Do not be that firm.

The Golden Rule: If you are reading the RFP for the first time on release day, the winner has already been decided in the government's mind. You are writing a proposal. They are executing a strategy.

2. The Strategic Partnership Analogy

Think of a federal agency as a large private-sector enterprise searching for a long-term strategic partner — not a one-time vendor. The Program Manager (PM) is their Chief Operating Officer: mission-obsessed, outcome-driven, risk-averse. The Contracting Officer (CO) is their Chief Financial Officer: compliance-first, process-bound, protective of the institution. You need both. Ignore one and you lose.

The agency is not shopping for the cheapest option. They are shopping for the lowest-risk path to mission success. Your entire capture strategy must answer one question for every stakeholder in that building: **Why is choosing us less risky than choosing anyone else?**

Past performance is your credibility. Relationships are your access. Solution shaping is your competitive moat. Price-to-Win (PTW) is your realism check. Bring all four or expect to lose.

3. Phase 1 — Intelligence Gathering & Pre-Positioning

Before you brief a single government stakeholder, you need to know their world better than they do. That is not arrogance — that is table stakes at this level. An executive who walks into an agency meeting without having studied their budget, their pain points, and their incumbent's weaknesses is wasting everyone's time.

Your Primary Intelligence Sources:

- **USASpending.gov** — Pull every active and recent contract the agency holds in your target space. Know who the incumbents are, what they are being paid, and when each contract expires. This is your competitive map.
- **SAM.gov** — Monitor the System for Award Management (SAM) for pre-solicitation notices, sources-sought announcements, and forecast data. Set alerts on every relevant North American Industry Classification System (NAICS) code and agency.
- **Congressional Budget Justifications (CBJ)** — The President's annual budget submission to Congress is the most underused intelligence document in the industry. It tells you exactly where an agency plans to invest for the next three to five years. Read it. Your competitors probably have not.
- **Freedom of Information Act (FOIA) Requests** — Incumbent contracts, performance evaluations, and Contractor Performance Assessment Reporting System (CPARS) ratings are obtainable through FOIA. If the incumbent has problems, this is where you find them.
- **Industry Days, RFIs, and Sources Sought** — These are not optional. They are your first legal touchpoint with the program office. Show up prepared. Submit substantive written responses. Be remembered for the right reasons.
- **LinkedIn and professional networks** — Map the entire program office. Know every key player — their career history, publications, and professional priorities. This intelligence shapes every conversation you have.

4. Phase 2 — Stakeholder Mapping & Relationship Building

At a multi-billion-dollar firm, we do not walk into agencies cold. Ever. Every meaningful conversation we have is the result of months of deliberate relationship investment. The government awards contracts to people they trust — full stop. Technical scores matter. But trust is the tiebreaker, and more often than you think, it is the deciding factor before the evaluation ever starts.

The Stakeholder Map — Know Every Player:

Stakeholder	Their Lens	What Drives Their Decisions	Your Engagement Strategy
Program Manager (PM)	Mission success	Will this reduce operational risk? Will it hit mission KPIs?	Lead with outcomes. Speak their mission language. Pitch results, never features.
Contracting Officer (CO)	Compliance & competition	Is this procurement legally defensible? Am I following the FAR correctly?	Respect every rule. Be transparent. Never attempt to circumvent them.
COR	Daily execution	Can these people actually deliver what they promise?	Demonstrate flawless past performance. Introduce your delivery team early.
Budget Analyst / CFO Staff	Return on investment	Can I justify this expenditure within our fiscal year spend plan?	Quantify value in dollars saved, hours recovered, or risk eliminated.
OSDBU	Small business utilization	Are large contractors meeting their subcontracting plans?	Build authentic teaming relationships. Know your SB subcontracting targets cold.

Stakeholder	Their Lens	What Drives Their Decisions	Your Engagement Strategy
SES / Agency Leadership	Strategic transformation	How does this contract advance agency mission and congressional priorities?	Brief at the strategic level. Connect your solution to headline agency priorities.

Relationship Principles That Actually Work at Scale:

• **Give before you ask — always.** Share a relevant white paper. Send a summary of a new GAO report affecting their program. Provide benchmark data. Establish yourself as a trusted resource, not a sales call waiting to happen.

• **The 3-Touch Minimum.** No meaningful government relationship is built in one meeting. My rule: three substantive engagements before anything resembling a business conversation — a conference introduction, a capabilities briefing, and a follow-up with actionable insight.

• **Never surprise a Contracting Officer.** COs operate in a world of rules and oversight. A surprise — even a positive one — creates anxiety. Predictability and transparency are how you build CO trust.

• **Engage during acquisition planning, not after.** If the agency is hosting a pre-solicitation meeting, draft PWS review, or market research session — your people need to be in that room.

• **Know the Procurement Integrity Act (PIA) cold.** The line between legal relationship-building and illegal information-gathering is real and consequential. Violations end careers and companies. There are no gray areas worth exploring.

5. Phase 3 — Solution Shaping & Competitive Positioning

This is where sophisticated capture teams separate themselves from the rest of the market. Solution shaping is the legal, proactive process of influencing what the government asks for — before they ask for it. FAR Part 15.201 explicitly encourages pre-solicitation communication between the government and industry. Most companies do not take full advantage of this. We do.

If your solution architecture becomes the template for the government's requirements, you have created a structural advantage that no competitor can overcome with price alone. That is the goal. It takes time. It takes discipline. And it is entirely within the rules.

Solution Shaping Tools:

- **RFI and Sources Sought Responses.** Write detailed, educational responses that subtly introduce your technical approach and metrics as industry best practices. Well-crafted RFI responses frequently appear — nearly verbatim — in draft PWS documents.
- **Unsolicited White Papers.** A well-researched, mission-focused white paper delivered to the right program office positions your firm as a thought leader and leaves a document they may reference when writing the solicitation.
- **One-on-One Capabilities Briefings.** Spend 20 minutes listening to their challenges for every 10 minutes you spend talking about your capabilities. Ask questions that reveal requirements gaps. Then address those gaps in follow-up materials.

Competitive Positioning:

- **Understand the incumbent's position deeply.** The government rarely replaces a contractor without cause. Find that cause through FOIA requests, CPARS data, and public contract modification records. Build your value proposition around their specific weaknesses — not your generic strengths.
- **Build a rigorous Price-to-Win (PTW) model.** PTW is not a gut feeling. It is an analytically derived price target built from GSA schedule rates, comparable contract awards on USASpending.gov, labor market data, and competitive bid history.
- **Assess the competitive field honestly.** Who else is pursuing this? What are their strengths? Who are they likely to team with? Identify your gaps against each competitor and close them — before the RFP drops.

> ***Competitive Intelligence Rule: Everything we gather is from legally available public sources — USASpending.gov, FOIA, SAM.gov, LinkedIn, and professional conferences. The moment you seek non-public procurement data, you have committed a federal crime under the Procurement Integrity Act.***

6. Phase 4 — Bid/No-Bid Decision Framework

Chasing the wrong opportunity is one of the most expensive mistakes in this industry. Proposal development costs $250K to over $1M for major bids — and it consumes your best people. A disciplined Bid/No-Bid gate is not a sign of weakness. It is competitive maturity. At a billion-dollar firm, every pursuit goes through a formal gate review. No exceptions.

Decision Factor	Green Light	Red Flag — Reconsider
Customer Relationships	Active, multi-level relationships with PM, CO, and at least one SES stakeholder	No prior contact with program office; first interaction is the RFP
Incumbent Position	Incumbent has documented performance issues or high staff turnover	Incumbent is entrenched, well-regarded; renewal is path of least resistance

Decision Factor	Green Light	Red Flag — Reconsider
Solution Fit	Core competency with directly relevant past performance references ready	Adjacent capability requiring significant stretch; no comparable CPARs
Competitive Landscape	Fewer than 4 credible competitors; no dominant incumbent advantage	Crowded field with a well-positioned incumbent and strong challengers
Price-to-Win Viability	Profitable delivery at or below analytically derived PTW target	Cannot deliver profitably at competitive price; cost structure misaligned
Proposal Resources	Senior proposal team available; key personnel confirmed with LOIs in hand	Key personnel unavailable; writing team stretched across concurrent bids
Strategic Value	Supports 3-year pipeline strategy; meaningful follow-on potential	One-off opportunity with no vehicle leverage or strategic adjacency

The Rule of 5: If fewer than five of the seven factors above are Green Lights at gate review time, the default position should be No Bid. Protect your proposal resources for opportunities where your competitive position is genuinely strong.

7. Phase 5 — Proposal Strategy & Win Theme Development

Capture management hands off to proposal management at RFP release. But the quality of that handoff determines whether the proposal team is executing a coherent strategy or improvising under deadline pressure. Every proposal we submit is built on a capture foundation — if that foundation is solid, the proposal writes itself. If it is not, no amount of writing talent saves you.

Developing Win Themes That Actually Win:

Win themes are not feature lists. They are not company history paragraphs. They are 3 to 5 compelling, customer-centric statements that answer one question for every evaluator: **Why you, and not someone else?**

- **Weak:** "We have 25 years of experience in cloud infrastructure."
- **Strong:** "Our FedRAMP High-authorized cloud migration methodology — deployed successfully across four Defense agencies — will reduce your data center operating costs by an estimated 32% within 18 months of award, with zero mission disruption during transition."

The strong theme is specific, quantified, tied to their mission priorities, and directly answers the evaluator's risk question. Every win theme in every section of your proposal must meet that standard.

Capture-to-Proposal Handoff Checklist:

- Customer hot buttons and priority pain points documented from direct engagement
- Price-to-Win target confirmed and approved by senior leadership
- All teaming partners finalized with executed Teaming Agreements (TA)
- Key personnel identified, committed in writing, and LOIs secured
- 3 to 5 win themes drafted, customer-validated where possible, and approved
- Past performance references pre-approved, relevant, and ready for submission
- Evaluation criteria cross-referenced against solution and win themes
- Competitive analysis summary delivered to proposal lead

8. The Relationship-Building Playbook

Government relationships operate on a longer timeline and under stricter rules than anything in the commercial world. The payoff — a trusted, durable agency partnership generating recurring revenue across multiple contract cycles — is worth every investment. Here is the system I have used and refined over 15 years at the top of this industry.

90-Day Relationship Launch Plan:

Timeline	Action	Objective
Days 1–30	Complete full intelligence build: agency org chart, active contracts, budget priorities, incumbent performance history. Identify top 3 target stakeholders.	Know their world before you enter it.
Days 31–45	Attend a relevant agency-hosted conference or Industry Day where target stakeholders will be present. Introduce yourself. Listen more than you speak.	Establish the first legitimate touchpoint.
Days 46–60	Follow up with a targeted, mission-relevant insight: a new GAO report, a benchmark study, or a brief analysis of a regulatory change affecting their program.	Position yourself as a resource, not a vendor.

Timeline	Action	Objective
Days 61–75	Request a 30-minute capabilities briefing. Structure it as 60% listening and 40% presenting. Ask questions that reveal their real challenges.	Move from acquaintance to trusted resource.
Days 76–90	Send a follow-up with a concrete idea tied directly to a challenge they raised. No pitch. Just value.	Establish trusted advisor status.

The Non-Negotiable Rules — What Will End Your Career and Your Company:

- **Never solicit or receive source selection information.** This is a felony under the Procurement Integrity Act. It does not matter how the government employee offers it. The answer is always no — and document that you said no.
- **Never exceed the $20 gift limit.** Meals, tickets, gifts, entertainment — all governed by Standards of Ethical Conduct and OGE regulations. There is no threshold worth testing.
- **Never go around the Contracting Officer.** If a program manager asks you to work outside the contract, your first call is to the CO. Unauthorized commitments create massive legal exposure for both parties.
- **Never make a commitment you cannot keep.** In government, your word is your past performance rating. One missed deliverable destroys a relationship that took years to build.

9. Capture Health Metrics

You cannot manage a capture pipeline you cannot measure. At a serious firm, the pipeline is reviewed by senior leadership weekly — with the same rigor applied to a financial portfolio. These are the metrics we track and the benchmarks we hold our teams to.

Metric	Definition	Target Benchmark
Pipeline TCV	Aggregate total contract value of all active capture pursuits	3x to 5x annual revenue target
Probability of Win (Pwin)	Capture team's assessed likelihood of winning each pursuit	35–50% weighted average across qualified pipeline
Capture-to-Bid Ratio	Opportunities actively pursued vs. proposals submitted	3:1 minimum — pursue three, formally bid one
Win Rate	Contracts awarded vs. proposals submitted over rolling 12 months	40%+ for well-qualified, gate-reviewed pursuits
Customer Engagement Frequency	Substantive stakeholder touchpoints per key account per month	2 to 4 per month per target account
B/NB Gate Compliance	Percentage of pursuits receiving formal gate review before bid decision	100% — no exceptions at any dollar threshold
Teaming Agreement Lead Time	Days before anticipated RFP release to finalize all teaming agreements	60 to 90 days minimum
Days to First Gov't Contact	Time from opportunity ID to first substantive agency engagement	Under 30 days for high-priority pursuits

10. The Mistakes That Cost You the Win

I have debriefed more loss notices than I care to count — from my own firm and from clients who hired us to figure out what went wrong. The same mistakes appear over and over.

- **Starting capture at RFP release.** At that point you are bidding on an RFP that a competitor had a hand in writing. You are already behind — and in most cases, you cannot catch up.
- **Treating all stakeholders with the same message.** The CO cares about compliance. The PM cares about mission outcomes. The SES cares about strategic transformation. One message does not serve three different audiences.
- **Using teaming as a substitute for capture.** Teaming with a large business or a set-aside firm supplements a strong capture position. It does not replace one.
- **Keeping capture intelligence in one person's head.** When your capture manager leaves — and they will — all of that relationship history walks out the door unless it is documented in a Customer Relationship Management (CRM) system.
- **Skipping post-award debriefs.** Win or lose, request a formal debrief. The government is required to provide one. Every debrief is a direct line into the evaluators' minds — a roadmap for your next pursuit.
- **Underestimating the incumbent advantage.** Your capture strategy must offer the government a compelling reason to accept transition risk. Marginal improvement is not enough. Differentiation is required.

11. Glossary of Essential Terms

Master this vocabulary. You will hear every one of these terms in your first week in a business development meeting. Do not be the person who has to ask.

FAR (Federal Acquisition Regulation) — The master rulebook governing all U.S. federal procurement.

BD (Business Development) — The function responsible for identifying, qualifying, and advancing new contract opportunities.

Capture (Capture Management) — The structured, pre-solicitation pursuit of a specific contract opportunity.

PWS (Performance Work Statement) — Government's description of required outcomes — what they want done, not how to do it.

SOW (Statement of Work) — Detailed task and deliverable description. More prescriptive than a PWS.

RFI (Request for Information) — Pre-solicitation market research. Your first legal opportunity to shape requirements.

RFP (Request for Proposals) — The formal solicitation. If you see it for the first time here, capture already failed.

CO (Contracting Officer) — The only government employee with legal authority to award, modify, or terminate a contract.

COR (Contracting Officer's Representative) — The CO's day-to-day oversight delegate. Manages technical performance on the ground.

PM (Program Manager) — The mission owner — the person whose operational problem you are solving.

CPARS (Contractor Performance Assessment Reporting System) — The government's official contractor performance rating database. Your most visible resume.

PTW (Price to Win) — Analytically derived price target at which you can win and deliver profitably.

LPTA (Lowest Price Technically Acceptable) — Evaluation method where the lowest compliant price wins. Margin is razor-thin.

Best Value (Best Value Continuum) — Evaluation method weighing technical quality against price. Where differentiation pays off.

IDIQ (Indefinite Delivery Indefinite Quantity) — Master contract vehicle enabling multiple task orders over time.

GWAC (Government-Wide Acquisition Contract) — Pre-competed, multi-agency vehicles — Alliant, OASIS, SEWP, etc. — enabling faster awards.

SAM (System for Award Management) — Central federal database for contractor registrations, solicitations, and award data.

NAICS (North American Industry Classification System) — Industry classification code determining size standard and set-aside eligibility.

OSDBU (Office of Small and Disadvantaged Business Utilization) — Agency small business advocacy office. Critical relationship for large and small firms alike.

PIA (Procurement Integrity Act) — Federal law prohibiting disclosure or receipt of contractor bid or proposal information. Violations are criminal.

FOIA (Freedom of Information Act) — Federal law enabling public access to government records — a powerful competitive intelligence tool.

SES (Senior Executive Service) — Senior leadership corps of the federal civil service. Typically the most strategically influential officials.

TCV (Total Contract Value) — Full dollar value of a contract including base period and all option periods.

LOI (Letter of Intent) — Written commitment from a key personnel candidate to join your team upon award.

FIELD NOTE // Start your capture 18 to 24 months before the anticipated solicitation date. The firms consistently winning the largest federal programs are not always the most technically capable — they are the most strategically disciplined. Positioning is built through relationships, intelligence, and solution shaping. None of that happens in the 30 days after an RFP drops. Build the relationship before you need the contract.